



The Italian peninsula was home to the Roman Empire, one of the greatest ancient civilizations. The south has two famous volcanoes, Vesuvius and Etna.



GEOGRAPHY

The Apennines form the backbone of a rugged peninsula, extending from the Alps into the Mediterranean Sea. Alluvial plain in the north.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean in the south. Seasonal extremes in the mountains and on the northern alluvial plain.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnically homogeneous, but with a gulf between the prosperous, industrial north and the poorer, agricultural south. Strong regional identities persist, especially on Sicily and Sardinia. Family ties remain strong, though the influence of the Roman Catholic Church has lessened.



INSIGHT: *Italy was a collection of dukedoms, monarchies, and city-states before unification in the 1860s*



THE ECONOMY

World leader in industrial and product design, fashion, textiles. Strong tourism and agriculture sectors. Large public sector debt.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Italian Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1861

CAPITAL: Rome

POPULATION: 59.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 116,305 sq. miles
(301,230 sq. km)

DENSITY: 527 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Italian*, German, French, Rhaeto-Romanic, Sardinian

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 85%, other and nonreligious 13%, Muslim 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Italian 94%, other 4%, Sardinian 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents